



Grit and grind: Alexander Zverev overcame a horrific ankle injury that tore three ligaments and left him writhing in pain during his 2022 French Open semifinal against Rafael Nadal.

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rather visors) off also to Sofia Kenin. The Russian-born American slumped badly after winning the Australian Open and making the French Open final in 2020 but rebounded in 2023 by upsetting Gauff at Wimbledon and ascending from No. 227 to No. 33.

IN HIS FIRST FULL PRO SEASON, BEN SHELTON, A ROCKET-SERVING AMERICAN LEFTY, ZOOMED FROM NO. 287 TO NO. 17



Mixed emotions: Neither giving birth to her first child in 2022 nor the anguish of her homeland's war against Russia's unprovoked invasion slowed the determined comeback of Elina Svitolina. GETTYIMAGES

MOST IMPROVED MEN'S PLAYER

A late-season surge gave Jannik Sinner a slight edge over Ben Shelton. With an improved net game and touch shots complementing Sinner's tremendous power, the 22-year-old led Italy to the Davis Cup title and reached the final at the Nitto ATP Finals. Sinner climbed from No. 15 to a career-high No. 4 by capturing four titles, including his first Masters 1000 in Toronto, and making his first major semifinal at Wimbledon. In his first full pro season, Shelton, a rocket-serving American lefty, zoomed from No. 287 to No. 17, thanks mostly to reaching the US Open semifinals — with wins over 10th-seeded Frances Tiafoe and No. 14 Tommy Paul — and the Australian Open quarterfinals.

MOST IMPROVED WOMEN'S PLAYER

My vote goes to Jasmine Paolini. The undersized (5'4") but highly consistent Italian had a modest ranking rise from No. 62 to No. 34, which didn't reflect her excellent season. Paolini reached 250 event finals at Jasmin Open Monastir and